

Lesson 11: How to Be a Leader No One Will Want to Leave

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Have you ever had a leader you would do anything for? Sometimes we like to make loyalty out to be a complicated, mythical element. In reality, it all comes down to one basic principle: trust. Mutual trust between an employer and a team member modeled first by the leader.

There are five basic principles of creating trust that we'll go over in the following lesson:

- Trust is automatically assumed.
- Team members are defended.
- Team members are allowed to do their jobs.
- Team members are allowed to give feedback.
- Good stewards are rewarded.

These five elements are a great place to start in establishing yourself as a leader no one will want to leave. In other words, world's greatest boss. Pat herself was quick to point out the merits of these principles and model them for her athletes. We all struggle in different areas. And as we go over the five principles in the lesson below, think about where you fall in these five.

Pat taught us that teamwork is really a form of trust. She said that when that happens, you surrender the mistaken idea that you can go at this alone. But you realize that you won't achieve your individual goals without the support of your colleagues. Pat also taught us that trust allows individuals to feel safe, supported, and respected, leading to a deeper connection and a better collaboration. Investing time and effort in building trust can lead to long-lasting, fulfilling relationships built on mutual understanding and respect.

As a young coach, Pat trusted me. We were playing in the SEC tournament for a championship. And we were down by one point, and coach trusted my scouting judgment against the team that we were playing against. I opted to foul immediately to give us more time to go down and call a play. So she hands me the clipboard. So we put the ball in our best player's hand, Candace Parker at this time. And we call 1-4 flat, which was also known as Virginia. And we actually got this play from the University of Virginia under the legendary coach Debbie Ryan. The 1-4 flat play, we drew it up, we came down, we missed the layup, another player came in, she was able to put the layup back in, and we were able to win a victory. But I want to say thank you, coach, for trusting me.